

INDIAN JEWELS

For thousands of years, jewellery has played an integral part in the history of India, not only as an art form but also as a spiritual talisman, a signifier of social position, and a means of diplomatic leverage. It was also a motive for political and military conflict, especially during the age of the Mughal emperors (1526–1707). Early jewels were made from stone beads, but Hindu texts from the 1st century BCE refer to a magical jewel called the Syamantaka that originally belonged to Surya the sun god. Able to produce gold and protect whoever possessed it, the jewel sparked clashes among the nobility in their efforts to claim ownership. Historians speculate that the gem was a diamond, possibly the Koh-i-noor, which is now part of the British Crown Jewels (see pp.58–59).

Diamonds have long been the most coveted gems in Indian cultures. Hindu god Krishna is said to have given a diamond to his lover Radha, so that it would reflect her beauty on moonlit nights. Legend says that diamonds were created when lightning struck rock, and they were believed to have healing powers – for example, the wealthy would sprinkle diamond powder on their teeth in the belief it would ward off lightning strikes and prevent tooth decay.

**The entire universe is
suspended from me as
my necklace of jewels**

Sri Krishna

Bhagavad Gita, 5th–2nd century BCE

Detail of a painting depicting Krishna's youth, 19th century

This painting shows the young Krishna playing the flute and bedecked in jewels, even though he is only a lowly cowherd. The elaborate jewellery elevates him to divine status, the lustre of the jewels outshining the sun.

